

The Techniques of *Genroku Theatre*: *Kabuki* and Chikamatsu's *Jôruri* Domestic Dramas

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Abstract

The aim of the present article is two-fold. First, it specifies dramaturgical traits of *kabuki* and *jôruri* plays produced around the Genroku period (1688-1704), when each actor showed off his own particular acting style (*geizukushi*). Second, it demonstrates how consciously and repeatedly Chikamatsu Monzaemon (1653-1725) employed the same dramaturgical format that he had learned from writing *sewa kyôgen* (*kabuki* domestic drama) to compose his *sewa jôruri*. Compared to Edo *kabuki*, which relied on a specific “world,” Kamigata plays were created through a combination of fixed patterns. This practice was introduced precisely because *Genroku kabuki* was a continuum of independent acting arts (*gei*) brought together by the leading actors who monopolized the show for a time. Therefore, it is natural that the structures of domestic drama, contrary to their “realistic” appearance, were built on existing play structures, such as *oie kyôgen* (plays about conflicts within the daimyô households). Chikamatsu's six works of *sewa jôruri*, all of which fall under the love-suicide subgenre, employed the *oie kyôgen* style. In other words, Chikamatsu played with the patterns of domestic drama and love-suicide plays, rather than put a lot of effort into making stories of literary value. Unlike the familiar image of the Chikamatsu who was indignant at feudal society, or the idealist who believed in the goodness of humankind, he was a sober formalist.

Introduction

Theatre is often believed to be a system of representation in which the actor's body functions as a medium for expressing the contents of a play. This, however, has only been true for the past hundred years of modern Western theatre, and the actor's body never originally was the mere medium of expression in any kind of theatre.

Especially in the case of *kabuki* during the Genroku era (1688-1704), as will be noted, the play was not something that existed *a priori*, but was completed through the rehearsal process. The charac-

teristics of *Genroku kabuki*, as it is called, rendered it a “play made through the body” in that, even if it could have been transcribed into the form of a script, it could easily be changed by the actors on stage. Thus a “script” was not a “play,” but simply a text for development by performing artists; this quality of the script remained basically unchanged, even after the establishment of the *kabuki* playwriting system.⁽¹⁾

In contrast, *jôruri* ⁽²⁾ plays were published and their texts essentially were fixed. Furthermore, this literary style employed a single speaker, and the play was written by an individual author. By the Genroku era, *jôruri* had established enough of its style as a form of theatre that it could not function without a narrator (*tayû*), shamisen (three-stringed musical instrument played with a plectrum), and puppets (*ningyô*). However, compared to *kabuki*, it was a form of theatre that focused much more on the play itself, which makes it much more accessible to modern research and appreciation.

In fact, to the extent that *jôruri* could endure the scrutiny of modern eyes—especially in the case of Chikamatsu Monzaemon’s (1653-1725) domestic dramas (*sewa mono*)—it has tended to be considered primarily as a form of literature; there was even a period during which it was enough to simply criticize or appraise its possibilities as literature for the modern age. Although this stance is seldom taken nowadays, I believe there still remains a tendency to futilely attempt to define literature so as to claim that such appraisal of literary value in Chikamatsu’s works would have no relevance to studying them.

The purpose of this paper is to gain an understanding of *kabuki* and *jôruri*, two forms of theatre completely different in nature, on the same plane. Thus the influence of *kabuki* on Chikamatsu’s *jôruri* domestic dramas plays will be treated by focusing purely on the issue of technique. *Kabuki* grew out of the performances of individual actors who created a set of techniques that could be passed on to later generations; since Chikamatsu also had served as a writer of *kabuki* plays, he must have fully mastered these techniques.

This paper is not meant to discuss “literature” in the modern sense, so I will not touch upon *sewa mono* as “tragedy” here. I will also refrain from discussing the nature and logic of ethics in feudal society as they are treated in these plays.

In what follows I begin by defining what is meant by the “Genroku era” in theatre; then, after clarifying the creative process for *Genroku kabuki*, I discuss how these techniques were adopted into Chikamatsu’s *sewa mono*.

(1) A system in which multiple writers belonging to a theatre troupe jointly authored a script. This was generally overseen by the main author called *tate sakusha* in the mid-Edo era. See SALTZMAN-LI (2010).

(2) *Jôruri* is a common term for the traditional puppet theatre widely known as *bunraku*; the latter term came into use in the late 19th century. In this paper, *jôruri* is used interchangeably with *bunraku*. Technically, however, *jôruri* can also refer to *kabuki* performances combining narrative and shamisen accompaniment. Many *kabuki* dances use *jôruri* accompaniment, which is one way in which the puppet theatre influenced *kabuki*.

The Genroku Era in Theatre

The Genroku era (1688-1704) was when *kabuki* developed significantly as a form of theatre; it was also when it reached its first stage of completion. In *kabuki* it is customary to define the Genroku era as the twenty-eight years that include but are not limited to the nominal Genroku era. This encompasses the period from the Jōkyō (1684-88) to the Hōei eras (1704-11). The first reason for this is that the actors at the forefront of contemporary *kabuki* were all active mainly in these periods. Sakata Tōjūrō I (1647-1709), Ichikawa Danjūrō I (1660-1704), and Nakamura Shichisaburō I (1662-1708) all gained prominence during these years⁽³⁾.

The second reason is that changes in the state and form of theatre-related publications coincided with the start of the Jōkyō and the end of the Hōei eras. The focus of the *Yakusha Hyōbanki* (Actor's Critiques) shifted from an evaluation of the actors' looks to their artistry; the first work in this new type of critique, *Yarō Tachiyaku Butai Ōkagami* (Great Mirror of Leading Male-Role Actors) appeared during Jōkyō. At the same time, the publication of the oldest known Kamigata region (Osaka-Kyoto) *Eiri Kyōgenbon* (Illustrated Kabuki Playbooks), which presents the play *Asukagawa* (Asuka River), is also thought to have appeared in the fourth year of Jōkyō (1687).⁽⁴⁾ The Kamigata versions of this illustrated series continued to be published until the end of the Kyōhō era (1716-1736), but during the preceding Shōtoku era (1711-15), the number of lines and characters in the text suddenly decreased, so that by the middle of Kyōhō, it had become centered on illustrations. On the other hand, the Edo versions of the illustrated books began with a play called *Sankai Nagoya* (Going to Nagoya), published in the tenth year of Genroku (1697), and disappeared at the end of Hōei (1710).⁽⁵⁾

Of the two reasons cited, that concerning publications emerges from the first, so the definition of the Genroku era in *kabuki* converges primarily on the issue of its actors. From its onset, *kabuki* developed around the importance of its actors. Thus, in the Genroku era, as *kabuki* acting, playwriting, and production features raised it to the level of a mature theatre genre, it was only a matter of course that the surging new generation of artists would push *kabuki* to a certain level, and that their demise would lead to its inevitable disintegration.

For example, Torigoe Bunzō believes the reason for the Kamigata illustrated *kabuki* playbooks' subsequent shift into illustration-centered publications is not because the dramatic contents had diminished but because the dramaturgy had become too complex to be annotated by simple remarks in a book. Why, then, did the plays become so complex? This can only be explained as the replacement of the old by a new generation of actors having led to an increased sophistication in performance.

(3) For further discussions, see TORIGOE (1991) and TSUCHIDA (1998).

(4) Historically, Kamigata maintained economic and cultural supremacy over Edo up to the mid 18th century.

(5) *Eiri kyōgenbon* were the closest thing to a published *kabuki* script before modern times. They were essentially illustrated versions of the scenarios, with selected dialogue and narrative forming part of the picture, like comic books.

Plays preserved on paper can be passed on to future generations, but performance is bound to its ephemerality. In addition, because the performance of actors differs according to their disposition (which is why the actor's body cannot be a transparent medium for expression), its complete replication is impossible. Consequently, only part of an acting approach is passed on to the next generation. The Genroku era was a period of *geizukushi*, that is, one in which each actor showed off his own particular acting style. And, even while the essence of *geizukushi* continued unchanged, acting that was impossible to reproduce seriatim was broken down into reproducible parts, thus creating *kata* (forms or patterns) for later generations that could be performed by anyone. In consequence, such standardized but diversified/ fragmented units of acting led to the formation of more complex plays.

As a side note, *Genroku kabuki* was the last such term to designate a particular stage in the development of early kabuki, beginning with *Okuni kabuki* (the original *kabuki* form created by Okuni of Izumo), *yūjo kabuki* (prostitute *kabuki*), *wakashu kabuki* (youth *kabuki*), and *yarō kabuki* (adult male *kabuki*). However, *Genroku kabuki* was not followed during the Edo era by any other term designating a type of *kabuki* by its era name. This symbolizes the current backward state of *kabuki* studies; nevertheless, it cannot be denied that Genroku was the age when *geizukushi* as the essence of *kabuki* appeared most definitively.

Interestingly enough, while we have *Genroku kabuki*, there is no *Genroku jōruri*. This speaks to the difference between *kabuki* and *jōruri* studies based in the Genroku period. *Genroku jōruri* is not as clearly defined as *Genroku kabuki*, although periodization according to the name of eras is not unsound since the political, economical, and cultural situations varied from era to era. Simply stated, *jōruri's Genroku* begins with the first year of Jōkyō (1684; recent years have seen a difference of opinion), when chanter Takemoto Gidayū (1651-1714) came on the scene, and continues to the death of Chikamatsu in Kyōhō 9 (1724). It was not until Kyōhō 8 (1723), when *shinjū mono* (lovers' suicide plays) were banned, that Kyōhō Reforms⁽⁶⁾ (1716-1745) had a serious impact on *jōruri*: therefore, it is next to impossible to see such an impact in Chikamatsu's existing pieces and to classify him as a Kyōhō author. On the other hand, as I frequently point out, his domestic dramas were strongly influenced by *Genroku kabuki*. For these reasons, Chikamatsu was a Genroku author.

Although I have used considerable space defining the Genroku era, it is necessary to confirm that, for *kabuki* at any rate, the period constituted a very special time in theatre history.

2. The Dramatic Structure of *Genroku Kabuki*

The dramatic structure of *Genroku kabuki* differed significantly between Kamigata and Edo. While Kamigata plays consisted of three acts, Edo plays had four or five. More importantly, the plays' thematic choices were different. In brief, Kamigata plays were *oie kyōgen* (plays about conflicts within

(6) The Kyōhō Reforms were a set of economic reforms, emphasizing frugality, instituted by the government to bring solvency to the shogunate.

daimyô households), while Edo plays were *jidai kyôgen* (plays focusing on pre-Edo-period history). Edo tended to seek its sources in earlier forms, like *kojôruri* (old *jôruri*)⁽⁷⁾ and *sekkyô* (dramatic sermons)⁽⁸⁾. In other words, its dramaturgy supposed a “world” (*sekai*), an established historical setting that functioned as a kind of vertical axis against which was placed a horizontal axis, the “dramaturgical device” (*shukô*). Thus the medieval Princess Chûjô,⁽⁹⁾ a *kojôruri* character, could be the underlying identity of Yaoya (Greengrocer) Oshichi, an Edo-period girl.⁽¹⁰⁾ By the same token, Edo *kabuki* had Sukeroku,⁽¹¹⁾ hero of a Kamigata lover’s suicide play, overlap with Soga no Gorô,⁽¹²⁾ a medieval avenging warrior.

Though Kamigata also saw historical plays, most plays there were built around daimyô household conflicts (*oie sôdô*). As the purpose of this paper is to evaluate the influence of *Genroku kabuki* on Chikamatsu’s domestic dramas, what follows discusses the aforementioned Kamigata *oie kyôgen*. An early actors’ critique provides a precise account of the basic plot of an *oie kyôgen*:

A young courtesan-buying⁽¹³⁾ lord is disowned; his stepmother and her evil chief retainer plot to take over the country; his faithful vassal throws away his life to work for the young lord. This plot can be seen in any play throughout the year.

(From *Ni no Kawari Gei Shina Sadame*,⁽¹⁴⁾ Kyôhō 16 (1731))

This describes the “old plot” that appeared after the Genroku era. In the three-act structure of Kamigata *kabuki*, the plot could be executed as follows:

(7) The 17th-century puppet theatre that preceded the performances of Takemoto Gidayû. .

(8) Narration-based performances fusing Buddhist prayers and folkloric stories of Japan during the Middle Ages.

(9) A legendary woman from the Nara era (8th century) said to have been despised by her stepmother and sent into the mountains, after which she retired into priesthood and wove the mandala of the Taima-dera Temple in one night. It typified the theme of a bullied stepchild.

(10) An actual figure from the early Edo era. Burnt out of her home by a fire, she falls in love with the beautiful boy in the temple to which she has escaped. Unable to forget her love even after her home has been rebuilt, she sets fire to her home so she can be reunited with him, and is sentenced to death.

(11) An actual figure from the mid-Edo era. He frequented a prostitute, Agemaki, in the brothels of Kyoto, and they eventually committed suicide together. This incident was dramatized in the Kamigata region, but when it was adapted in Edo, it melded with the story of the *kyôkaku* (professional gambler often romanticized as a chivalrous “Robin Hood” type of character) Tôzawa Sukeroku, establishing the image of the *otokodate* (chivalrous man who helps the poor and weak) character.

(12) A figure from the early Kamakura era (late 12th century). Together with his brother, Jurô, they enacted revenge upon their father’s enemy, Kudô Suketune. It became a frequently dramatized subject of revenge plays.

(13) That is, *keisei kai*, purchasing the services of high-class prostitutes or courtesans.

(14) *Ni no Kawari Shina Sadame*, the critique’s title, means “The Evaluation of the New Year’s Programs”.

Act One

- generally composed of two scenes, *kuchiake* (Scene 1) and *nakairi* (Scene 2).
- The lord of a certain house already is dead, or, if alive, is an old man who no longer has any power.
- the young lord has already been disowned due to his brothel frequenting, and no longer lives at home, or is driven away and deprived of his samurai status (*ahôbarai*) during the *kuchiake*.
- the young lord's mother, that is, the lord's former wife, is dead, and a lustful stepmother has seized much of the real power.
- the stepmother either has her own child that she wants to install as the head of the house, or is in cahoots with the family's evil chief retainer to take over the household. In some cases, this retainer's role may be filled by the stepmother's child or siblings. This scheme is commonly revealed in the *kuchiake*. As a result there is a scene of a scuffle and, if the lord is alive, he normally dies at this time.
- the exiled young lord often appears in the *nakairi* disguised as a day laborer or palanquin bearer. He is also commonly betrothed to a princess, and sometimes happens to see her in his disguised form. However, in contrast to the princess's emotions, the young lord thinks only of his courtesan mistress.
- often, an apparition of some sort appears in the *nakairi*. The living ghost of the princess may appear to reproach the young lord.

Act Two

- like Act One, Act Two is typically composed of a *kuchiake* and *nakairi*.
- in plays featuring the word *keisei* in the title, like those performed during the New Year's program, a scene in the brothel district commonly appears in the *nakairi* and sometimes in the *kuchiake*.
- the red-light district scene often contains many highlights, such as a procession of courtesans, the disguised young lord meeting his courtesan mistress, a quarrel between them, or something to do with the faithful servant. The set for the brothel is often built in two stories, providing an amusing effect as people pass each other going up and down.
- at the end of the brothel scene, the courtesan's contract is happily paid for.
- a domestic scene (*sewaba*) is often included in the *kuchiake*. It may be the home of a simple townsman, the residence of the faithful servant trying to protect the young lord, or a variety of other abodes, but these often have some relationship to the young lord. Here, people in financial difficulty appear, setting the stage for someone in need to commit a murder.

- a “fool,” played by a comic actor (*dôkeyaku*), can provide an acting highlight both in the domestic scene and the brothel scene.
- the evil chief retainer, stepmother, and other antagonists that appeared at the beginning are either rooted out in this *nakairi*, or remain until the third act.

Act Three

- the antagonists not rooted out in Act Two are eliminated.
- a denouement occurs in which the young lord regains his home.
- the play ends in most cases with a dance finale, or a showing of technical effects. In some plays featuring a temple's display of Buddhist imagery (*kaichô mono*)⁽¹⁵⁾ there is often a dance related to the shrine or temple.

Compared to Edo *kabuki*, which relied on a specific “world,” Kamigata plays were created, as described above, rather freely through a combination of fixed patterns. As in Edo *kabuki*, each scene was highly independent with an extensive change of actors between the first and second acts. This pattern was introduced precisely because *Genroku kabuki* was a continuum of independent acting arts (*gei*) brought together by the leading actors who played at a set length. There were other reasons as well, like the rehearsal circumstances, considerations of each role type, to assist the audience's understanding, but all in all, the notion of *geizukushi* took precedence.

Now let us look at the actual process by which a play took form. According to *Kaneko Ikkô Nikki* (The Diary of Kaneko Ikkô⁽¹⁶⁾ hereafter *Diary*), discovered by Wada Osamu,⁽¹⁷⁾ we see that plays were completed in roughly the following steps:⁽¹⁸⁾

1. First came the planning (*an*) of the play. Most of this work was undertaken by Kaneko alone.
2. Kaneko and Chikamatsu discussed (*sôdan*) and consulted (*dango*) with the actors on the planning, and the basic plot (*kyôgen*) was completed (*dekiru*).
3. They explained (*hanasu*) the basic plot with influential actors like actor-manager (*za-moto*) Sakata Tôjûrô, Yamatoya Jinbei, and Mizuki Tatsunosuke.
4. Once the consent of the actor-manager was earned, rehearsals (*keiko*)⁽¹⁹⁾ began. This was

(15) Kabuki play with the theme of exhibiting a Buddhist image.

(16) Kaneko Ikkô, also known as Kaneko Kichizaemon, was both an actor and a playwriting collaborator of Chikamatsu's.

(17) WADA (1994).

(18) Kaneko uses a number of specific terms that are introduced here in bracketed italics.

(19) As noted in the text, it is believed that, in the Genroku era, there was no fully completed script, so the rehearsal was different from what it is now. It was a process in which actors worked out their lines and movements during the practice.

where the details were decided for the first time. The plot development (*shigumi*) was also worked out at this time.

5. The movements patterns (*kata*) used in the choreography (*furitsuke*) and fight scenes (*tachimawari*) were added.

6. A dress rehearsal (*sôgeiko*) was conducted on stage. Spectators were let in at this time.

Comparing this process with later *kabuki* productions in the mid to late Edo period (late 18th to 19th centuries), when the atelier system of *kabuki* playwrights (*kyôgen sakusha-beya*)⁽²⁰⁾ was established, we can understand the specific aspects of Genroku playmaking.

Under the later system, as noted in Kawatake Mokuami's memorandum, *Kyôgen Sakusha Kôkoroegaki* (Instructions for Kabuki Playwrights; hereafter "Instructions"), the steps for writing a play were as follows:

First the chief playwright (*tate sakusha*) worked out the concept and, with the second-level (*nimaime sakusha*) and third-level (*sanmaime sakusha*) playwrights, created a draft (*yokogaki*). Next a script reading (*naiyomi*) with the company leader (*zagashira*)⁽²¹⁾ was conducted at the latter's home,⁽²²⁾ and after some revisions, the playwright read the script (*honyomi*) before the assembled company in the third-floor dressing room. Based on this reading, the fourth and fifth-level playwrights in the playwriting atelier (*kyôgen kata*) and apprentice playwrights at the bottom of the hierarchy (*minarai sakusha*) drafted the actors' sides (*kakinuki*), script fragments containing only individual actors' lines, and distributed them to the cast. Accepting the sides was a sign that the actor had accepted the role. Line rehearsals were conducted using the sides, and this was followed by the "on your feet rehearsal" (*tsuketate* or *tachigeiko*), where the actors moved about without looking at their lines, and a partial dress rehearsal (*sôzarai*), conducted with musical instruments and songs, after which the opening day would arrive.

The *naiyomi* reading between playwright and leading actor in the "Instructions" corresponds to step 3 in the *Diary*, where it is called *hanasu* (talk) instead of *yomu* (read). If step 3 in the *Diary* corresponds to *naiyomi* in the "Instructions," then the reading before the entire company (*honyomi*) in the "Instructions" should take place before step 4 in the *Diary*. But this step is missing there and rehearsal instantly begins. In order to rehearse, the actors had to have their sides, but there is no mention of this in the *Diary*. While Chikamatsu and Kaneko assumed roles like drafting the signboards or managing the props, in other words, menial tasks that would later be completed by the low-level

(20) System in which multiple writers belonging to a theatre troupe jointly authored a script.

(21) While there was no script in the Genroku era and the plot was only talked out (*hanasu*), by the late Edo era the script was written out and read.

(22) The *zagashira* was essentially an actor-manager, being the designated company head and thus the most influential of the actors, supervising them, and possibly directing, although stage direction was not a recognized activity. This position was originally called the *zamoto*, but in the late Edo era, it was divided into the producer, or *zamoto*, and actor-manager, or *zagashira*.

playwrights (*kyôgen kata*), there is no record of them having undertaken the job of writing the sides. This may suggest that there was no actual script (*daihon*), complete with lines and stage directions (*togaki*). The expression that a “play” (*kyôgen*) is “completed” (*dekiru*) is sometimes used, but this should be understood to mean only that a part of the play, or the overall rough plot, had been established.

Thus rehearsal, as per the *Diary*, was not a process for memorizing the lines in the sides. The rehearsal itself might have been, instead, the process during which the actors’ lines and movements were concretized. The issue here is the word *shigumi*, used almost synonymously for rehearsal with the word *keiko*. While *keiko* was a generic term for the creative process, I believe that *shigumi* meant a process of reorganizing reproducible existing acting methods and approaches, as comprised by the previously mentioned word *kata*.

At the same time, it is no exaggeration to state that a master script with a complete set of lines and stage directions actually existed for the purpose of providing the sides, but it is questionable whether it was common in the Genroku era. It is said that the script was first conceived by Kaneko himself, but it was likely only a kind of memo with no distinction between the stage directions and lines, as indicated in the *Kyôgen no Sujigaki* (Play’s Scenario) discovered prior to the *Diary* (the *Diary* was found written on the reverse side of the paper in this document). The oldest-known script currently in existence is from the Hôei era, but it is also possible that this may simply be a record of a rehearsal.

3. The Technique of *Sewa Kyôgen*

In theory, the system in which plays are conceived through rehearsals has the advantage of maximizing the actors’ creativity, but it sometimes leads to the over-inflation of details that ruin the play as a whole. The nature of *kabuki*, however, is such that the actor’s artistry (*gei*) is brought to the forefront, even at the sacrifice of the overall plot, so this seeming demerit actually does not constitute a flaw. Moreover, this defect of *kabuki* has some connection with domestic dramas (*sewa kyôgen*).⁽²³⁾

Domestic dramas were the result of information based on actual current events that had been quickly dramatized into short dialogue plays. Many were performed at the end of multiple-act plays (*tsuzuki kyôgen*), as independent, supplementary plays (*kiri kyôgen*). Because their subjects were limited to news about the merchant class (*chônin*), domestic dramas did not display as much diversity in acting styles as the multiple-act plays, such as the *oie sôdô* genre about *daimyô* family conflicts, and had to be composed of relatively realistic lines and actions.

Besides, *kabuki* did not use an abstract stage space like *nô* or *kyôgen*. The Genroku-era stage consisted of a three ken or 5.454 meter square space inherited from *nô*, with a bridgeway (*hashigakari*) that had been widened; at times, a temporary forestage (*tsuke butai*) was added at the front. However,

(23) The term is synonymous with *sewa mono*.

while it was impossible to introduce a large, complex stage set due to difficulties in moving it in and out, an attempt was made to make it as realistic as possible. For instance, once a scene was set as the mansion of a certain samurai family, no matter how poor the set on the bare stage, it would have to function as the samurai residence until the end of the scene. In this regard, Tsuchida Mamoru suggests the possibility that, in *Keisei Asamagatake* (The Courtesan at Asamagatake),⁽²⁴⁾ the stage itself could have served for the floor of the samurai residence, without the need for a new set, and he suggests that the orchestra area (*hiradoma*) was used for acting a scene that took place in the cellar.⁽²⁵⁾ If this were the case, and supposing that the next scene was outdoors, the samurai residence floor would have had to be changed to the ground outside. To do so, there must have been a clear change on stage, such as by drawing the curtains, or changing the scenic props. Perhaps this is why the last scene in many *Genroku kabuki* plays ended with stage combat; when all the actors were running around chasing or being chased, the stage became empty of actors, and could be newly used for a different scene, thus creating a theatrical convention.

Let us compare this convention with that of the Shakespearean stage: in the latter, even on the same bare stage, once Antonio exits and Portia enters, the scene moves from the streets of Venice to Portia's home; or once Romeo descends from the balcony, the stage is transformed into Juliet's room which should be located on the upper floor. This kind of switching between spaces is impossible in *kabuki* because it is a kind of theatre that portrayed the manners and customs of the townspeople following its own realistic concerns, as represented by *keisei kai* plays about young lords dallying in the brothel quarters.

With such theatre, instead of switching scenes, a technique developed to keep the location fixed with the characters constantly entering and existing. And, under these circumstances, characters that were on stage received different information than those that were off, creating an information gap that became the starting point for dramatic conflict.

This technique was fully exploited in *Genroku kabuki*. Overdoing it, however, sometimes resulted in unbalanced play structures. I will explain this briefly.

Uzuki Kokonoka Sono Akatsuki no Myôjô ga Chaya (Dawn of the Ninth Day of the Fourth Month at Myôjô Teahouse) was first performed at Kyoto's Miyako Mandayû-za in the fifth month of 1697. Myôjô ga Chaya, which we will call it for short, has an extremely complicated structure with characters entering and exiting frequently. The first scene, set in "The Fertilizer Shop of Yasobei, Matsuzaka, Ise," among others, is divided into twelve sequences based on the characters' comings and goings; these sequences are supported by twenty-two acting units accompanied by cues for entrance and exits.

The story begins with a coincidence: the sales clerk of the fertilizer shop, Jûemon (Mikasa Shiroemon), finds a letter and a key in the pouch of his master, Yasabee (Kaneko Kichizaemon). The letter

(24) First performed in Kyoto in 1698, it is a masterpiece of the *oie sôdô* genre about conflicts in *daimyô* households.

(25) TSUCHIDA (1996).

is from a girl, Akita Oyoshi of the Myôjô Teahouse (Tamagawa Handayû), to another clerk, Kuemon (Sakata Tôjûrô), while the key belongs to a cash box containing eight pieces of gold reserved for the Ise Shrine pilgrimage. Jûemon removes the key and steals the money. Then, taking advantage of the secret letter to Kuemon, he puts the blame on him, and Kuemon is banished from the shop. This is the rough plot of the first scene.

In the second scene, set at the teahouse, Jûemon weds Oyoshi and is adopted into her family. Oyoshi, however, opposes this and wants to run away with Kuemon, but her feelings are not conveyed to her lover, who is hiding out and planning to stab both Oyoshi and Jûemon. Jûemon's evil deeds are revealed at the end.

The actions of the characters contain many discrepancies; for example, Jûemon, after stealing the money, accidentally drops a gold piece out of fear and pays a gold piece to Tarôza (Tenjô Mataemon), who witnessed his dropping it, adding another gold piece to ensure he keeps his mouth shut. Then, to obtain Oyoshi's hand, Jûemon uses five gold pieces to cover the debt of Oyoshi's mother, widow of the merchant Akitaya (Matsumoto Rokuemon). Jûemon's making both ends meet could only have been possible if he had foreseen the chain of events right from the start. This is not only unique to Jûemon's case, but also to the other characters, as their actions are constructed backwards to compose the story, which clouds our understanding of why they would take the various actions that they do.

These defects are improved in the domestic scenes of the following two Genroku plays produced at Kyoto's Miyako Mandayû-za: *Keisei*⁽²⁶⁾ *Edo Zakura* (Courtesans and Edo Cherry Blossom; 1698) and *Keisei Fuji Miru Sato* (Courtesans and Mt. Fuji Viewing Village; 1701). The second scene in both plays, while maintaining the basic structure of *Myôjô ga Chaya*, has fewer dramaturgical discrepancies. The plays are nominally attributed to Chikamatsu, who was also involved in *Myôjô ga Chaya*. However, it is more likely that that play, as well as the two domestic scenes, were conceived by Kaneko. As noted later, however, Chikamatsu would come to use the techniques of kabuki domestic dramas and domestic scenes, acquired during his time in the same troupe with Kaneko, in his bunraku domestic plays.

By comparing the following *kabuki* domestic dramas, we are able to discover something of value: *Myôjô ga Chaya*, *Shinjû Chaya Banashi* (Story of Teahouse Love Suicides; 1700), *Yotsubashi Musume Goroshi* (Killing of a Girl at Yotsubashi; 1702), and *Kawara Shinjû* (Love Suicides by the Riverbed; 1703).

The structure of these plays reveals that kabuki domestic dramas, contrary to their "realistic" appearance, did not portray the events as they happened, but were built on existing play structures, such as that of the *oie kyôgen*. Matsuzaki Hitoshi remarks that the *kabuki* domestic drama *Komeya Shinjû* (Love Suicide of a Rice Dealer) established a certain pattern for love suicide plays that can be called the "*Komeya Shinjû* style."⁽²⁷⁾

(26) The word *keisei* was customarily added to the title of all Kamigata New Year's plays.

(27) MATSUZAKI (1979).

Shinoda Jun'ichi, on the other hand, calls attention to the emotional acting visible in the corresponding central acts of three-act *kabuki* and *bunraku* domestic dramas, and to that in the central act, set in a brothel, of three-act *oie kyôgen*.⁽²⁸⁾ Shinoda's observation could be extended, in my view, to the first act of both genres. In the *oie kyôgen*, the usurpation of the household and exile of the young lord happen in the first act, while in many *kabuki* domestic dramas, such as *Myôjô ga Chaya*, the protagonist is beaten for some reason and banned, which resembles the *oie kyôgen* convention of the casting off of the hero and depriving him of his samurai status (*ahôbarai*). If the *kabuki* domestic drama's driving force is the conflict between "money" and "love," these two factors can be concretized as the "social downfall of the main male character" and the "emotional scene between a male and female character in a dangerous situation." As noted below, this formula could have facilitated Chikamatsu's creations of his own domestic tragedies.

Furthermore, the murder in *Myôjô ga Chaya* would have been changed to a lovers' suicide if Kyûemon and Oyoshi had been able to develop a mutual understanding in the second scene. This means that the play's ending could have changed freely depending on the starting point, where the initial information gap between the characters is aggravated in order to produce dramatic conflict. This consideration leads to another question: is it proper to classify the *kabuki* domestic drama genre by its content? Or should it instead be determined by the dramatic structure?

4. The Technique of Chikamatsu's *Sewa Jôruri*

Finally, we examine the technique of Chikamatsu's *bunraku sewa jôruri* or domestic dramas. While there exists uncertainty about the number of plays Chikamatsu wrote in the genre, I will assume his *sewa jôruri* includes twenty-four works, counting *Uzuki no Iroage* (Re-dying Springtime Crimson) and *Uzuki no Momiji* (Autumn Leaves in Spring) as a single piece of work, the latter being the former's sequel.

In view of seeing the continuity between *Genroku kabuki* and Chikamatsu's puppet play techniques, we must consider how his *sewa jôruri* have been classified in previous studies. Suwa Haruo, after listing all the conventional classification methods, has noted that "classification by content has a certain limit."⁽²⁹⁾ He then applied his own classification method based on various aspects of the plays. However, this resulted in his comment: "there is practically no difference between it and conventional classifications...."

Notwithstanding these results, I think it possible to distinguish two groups of plays based on structure, whether the plays have an *oie kyôgen* structure or not. Here, plays containing a scene of a man's social downfall and an emotional scene between a man and woman will be classified as *oie kyôgen* style and those not equipped with these scenes will be defined as non-*oie kyôgen* style.

(28) SHINODA (1991).

(29) SUWA (1974).

According to this classification, seven Chikamatsu works can be marked as *oie kyôgen* style: *Sonezaki Shinjû* (Love Suicides at Sonezaki; 1703), *Shinjû Nimai Ezôshi* (Two Love Suicide Picture Books; 1706), *Uzuki no Momiji/Uzuki no Iroage* (1706/07), *Shinjû Yaiba wa Kôri no Tsuitachi* (The Blade of Love Suicide Falls on the Icy First Day; 1709), *Shinjû Mannensô* (Love Suicide at Mount Kôya; 1710), *Imamiya no Shinjû* (Love Suicides at Imamiya; 1711), and *Ikutama Shinjû* (Love Suicides at Ikutama; 1715). All fall under the love suicide (*shinjû mono*) subgenre, and, of the ten works (not counting *Uzuki no Iroage*), seven can be classified as *oie kyôgen* style.

Of the non-*oie kyôgen* style love suicide plays, the following do not include the male character's downfall: *Shinjû Kasaneizutsu* (The Love Suicides and the Kasaneizutsu Prostitute⁽³⁰⁾; 1707), *Shinjû Ten no Amijima* (The Love Suicides at Amijima; 1720), and *Shinjû Yoigôshin* (Love Suicides on the Eve of the Kôshin Festival; 1722). In *Shinjû Kasaneizutsu*, the heroine has parents suffering from debt, which triggers the love suicide. As for *Shinjû Ten no Amijima* and *Shinjû Yoigôshin*, neither hero nor heroine shares the pattern of social downfall seen in the *kabuki* domestic drama genre.

Apart from *shinjû mono*, the techniques learned from *kabuki* are present in Chikamatsu's other *bunraku* domestic dramas as well: *Gojûnenki Utanenbutsu* (Fiftieth Anniversary Buddhist Prayer Song; 1707) has both the scene of the man's downfall as well as an emotional scene, but unlike *oie kyôgen* where each is rendered independently, they are mixed into a single scene, thereby excluding this work in the strict sense from the *oie kyôgen* style. *Yodogoi Shusse no Takinobori* (The Yodo River Carp's Successful Swim up the Waterfall; 1708) has a structure closer to the original *kabuki oie kyôgen*; however, it lacks the scene of the hero's downfall. *Yûgiri Awa no Naruto* (Yûgiri and the Straits of Naruto; 1712) develops the brothel scene from *oie kyôgen* as an independent play, and consequently does not have the overall structure of the *oie kyôgen* style.

When we return to the seven *oie kyôgen*-style works mentioned above and examine them in detail we see their similarities, the first being the number of scenes. In these seven *shinjû mono*, the scenes of "the male character's downfall," "the emotional scene," and the scenes of traveling (*michiyuki*) and love suicide, are placed in each act, respectively.

Second is the issue of time. Excluding the slightly longer *Ikutama Shinjû*, the seven *shinjû mono* stories unfold in an extremely short period of time, within two to three days from start to finish (when the lovers' suicide is committed). The dramatic principle of these plays is to condense the lives of their characters into the days just before they kill themselves. Tsubouchi Shôyô (1859-1935),⁽³¹⁾ a pioneer of Japanese theatre studies who compared Chikamatsu to Shakespeare, would call this technique the "retrospective explosion" style, or the "convergent" style in Western classical drama. Of all the *bunraku* domestic dramas, only *shinjû mono* deal with so short a period of time. The difference will be clearer when we compare these plays with others closer to the *oie kyôgen* genre such as *Gojûnenki*

(30) The prostitute's name Kasaneizutsu is based on a complex, untranslatable play on words.

(31) Tsubouchi Shôyô was a reformer of *kabuki* who also introduced Shakespeare to Japan in the late 19th century.

Uta Nenbutsu, which covers a period of more than one month, or *Yodogoi Shusse Takinobori*, which depicts the events of three years.

Thirdly, in six of the above *shinjû mono*, the male character's downfall involves a mistake concerning a small item: the letter of credit that Kuheiji is forced to write in *Sonezaki Shinjû*; the blunder with the key and letter, similar to *Myôjô ga Chaya*, in *Shinjû Nimai Ezôshi*; the inheritance deed in *Uzuki no Iroage/Uzuki Momiji*; the slip-up with the letter at the start of *Shinjû Mannensô*; the confusion with the marriage arrangement letter and Ieshichi's letter of mortgage in *Imamiya no Shinjû*, and Nagasaku's letter in *Ikutama Shinjû*. Only *Shinjû Yaiba wa Kôri no Tsuitachi* does not include such an item.

Fourth is the "plot device of hiding," which Suwa also adopts for his classification; this is the situation in which the protagonist hides himself for some reason, found in the six *shinjû mono* other than *Ikutama Shinjû*. The device is not found in *Shinjû Ten no Amijima* or *Shinjû Yoigôshin*.

Examining these plays, we can see that, other than *Ikutama Shinjû*, written at a later time, Chikamatsu repeatedly uses the techniques acquired from *kabuki* domestic drama for the six works from *Sonezaki Shinjû* to *Imamiya no Shinjû*. Furthermore, this is practically limited to *shinjû mono* and is scarcely found in his other *bunraku* domestic dramas, which treat adultery, punishment (or crime), or a fiction created by the playwright. Could it be a coincidence that *Imamiya no Shinjû* was written in the first year of Shôtoku (1711), or near the end of *Genroku kabuki*?

It must also be noted that of these six works, the first three are distinguished from the others according to their disposition; in *Sonezaki Shinjû*, *Shinjû Nimai Ezôshi*, and *Uzuki no Iroage/Uzuki Momiji*, the male and female characters have much difficulty in confirming each other's will to commit lovers' suicide, as represented by Ohatsu and Tokubei, in *Sonezaki Shinjû*. In the last three, namely, *Shinjû Yaiba wa Kôri no Tsuitachi*, *Shinjû Mannensô*, and *Imamiya no Shinjû*, confirmation of intent is not given as much emphasis. I should also point out that, while in the first three works the female characters do not share the cause for the suicides, in the last three, their similar circumstances, such as a call back to their hometowns or a marriage agreement, are involved.

The analysis thus far clearly indicates there is a common technique to *shinjû mono*. It is possible that Chikamatsu changed his technique according to the materials he treated, as seen in Suwa Haruo's classification, which also resulted in a material-based grouping. We could say that Chikamatsu consciously applied the techniques of *kabuki* domestic drama, at least for *shinjû mono* until a certain period, while further research is needed for other types of plays.

Why did Chikamatsu repeatedly use a similar theatrical device? To say that he simply relied on the techniques of *kabuki* with which he was very familiar is an all too easy answer. While it is true that Chikamatsu was more engaged in writing his full-length *bunraku* plays, previous studies have shown that he also applied the utmost care to the wording of his *sewa jôruri* as indicated in the research of

Yûda Yoshio,⁽³²⁾ Shinoda Jun'ichi,⁽³³⁾ and Tokimatsu Takafumi,⁽³⁴⁾ among others.

Shinoda and Tokimatsu, in particular, point out that Chikamatsu calculated the effect of his work. He tried to provoke the audience's subconscious and direct their emotions by including keywords for each work and hinting at previous work in the genre. For example, the keyword for *Uzuki Momiji* is "embrace," which suggests another work, *Shinjû Daki Botan* (Love Suicides Embracing the Tree Peony), and the keyword for *Horikawa Nami no Tsuzumi* (Drum of the Waves of Horikawa) is "waiting." While there is a slight difference in usage, the device of clutching the tempered blade in *Shinjû Yaiba wa Kôri no Tsuitachi* is clearly reminiscent of *Keisei Edo Zakura*.

Although I have not made a detailed inquiry, there must be countless other examples of this sort. Thus Chikamatsu, who was so conscious of selecting words, would never have been remiss about his play structure.

Conclusion

It is very likely that Chikamatsu applied techniques commonly used in *Genroku kabuki* to his *bun-raku* love suicide plays. This hypothesis is supported by the fact that in Kamigata *Genroku kabuki*, the three-act *oie kyôgen* pattern was generally used and that *kabuki* domestic drama adopted this and created its own format. It is further collaborated by the fact that the author of *Myôjô ga Chaya* (probably Kaneko), who was faced with its dramaturgical discrepancies, subsequently used this technique in *Keisei Edo Zakura* and *Keisei Fuji Miru Sato*.

Chikamatsu as a kabuki playwright presumably did not have as much freedom as Kaneko in directing actors. However, as a *jôruri* dramatist, Chikamatsu could move puppets around on his desk as he liked.

By focusing on the issue of technique in theatre, we find Chikamatsu a sober formalist who played with the patterns of domestic drama and love suicide plays, unlike the Chikamatsu who was indignant at feudal society, or the idealist who believed in the goodness of humankind. Here begins theatre freed from the realm of literature.

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